

(GNOME Do, Synapse, Kupfer, Unity's Dash, GNOME Shell, etc) are mainly focused on keyboard input—I wanted to create something which could be used with your mouse only.” And so GNOME Pie was born and released to the public in September 2011.

User interface

GNOME Do is summoned using <Super+Spacebar> where ‘Super’ is the Windows (or if you’re lucky, Ubuntu) icon key. GNOME Do has a simple two-pane user interface (UI). Your typed text and match show up in one pane while the other pane shows the actions possible. There is a tiny cross icon in the top left hand corner for closing Do and an equally tiny icon in the top right hand corner, which opens a menu that includes the ‘About Do’, ‘Preferences’, ‘Donate’ and ‘Quit’ options. The UI is fully customisable; you can choose a theme and the background colour as well.

GNOME Pie has a unique and intuitive interface. It is a circular application launcher and can be navigated by using both the mouse and the keyboard, though using the mouse is preferable. The UI consists of a central display circle surrounded by the items. The user can choose from several themes such as ‘Funky’, ‘Glossy’ and even some OS-specific themes such as ‘Elementary’ and ‘Unity’. I found the ‘pie’ UI concept cute and refreshing—the only drawback being the lack of icons sometimes. GNOME Pie also has a notification tray icon, which on being clicked shows ‘Preferences’, ‘About’ and ‘Quit’.

Synapse is best thought of as a floating search bar that can be activated using <Ctrl+Spacebar>. You type in the text, and the icon of a matching application will be shown. You can use the side arrow keys to access filters such as ‘Documents’, ‘Images’, and ‘Videos’, which help narrow the search. Synapse’s UI can also be themed. There are six themes to choose from, including ‘Do-ish’, which turns Synapse into a perfect GNOME Do clone! Synapse also has a notification tray icon, which on being clicked shows the ‘Activate’, ‘Preferences’ and ‘Quit’ options.

Functionality and ease of use

Launching applications from GNOME Do is fairly straightforward. Just type in the name and hit ‘Enter’. Searching is equally simple and surprisingly powerful. The plugins allow Do to search your Tomboy notes, Firefox bookmarks, Banshee and, of course, your files and folders. Your search can also include your Google Calendar events and Google Docs if you provide your user details to the program. GNOME Do also allows you to set simple reminders and find word definitions using GNOME dictionary. These features work well; however, as I experienced with the *Reminder* option, users need to learn how to phrase the command to use these features

properly. The syntax, though simple, is not necessarily obvious and often leads to a Google search or two. Oh, and did I mention that all the features mentioned so far are just a *small part* of the ‘Official Plugins’? And that Official Plugins are roughly half of ‘Community Plugins’? With such powerful add-ons, you can do literally *anything* from the comfort of Do’s two pane UI.

An innovative twist to GNOME Pie is that it consists of several ‘pies’. For instance, there is an ‘Applications’ pie, a ‘Multimedia’ pie and so on. Each pie has a different keyboard shortcut. Users can, of course, create their own pies. Each item in the pie is called a ‘slice’, and users can add their own slices with some basic command line knowledge. Unlike Do, GNOME Pie does not have a search function. Though it has some additional features like being able to control multimedia playback with a pie, it primarily is an application launcher. This is not a bad thing since simplicity has its own benefits. Many users will find GNOME Pie intuitive and useful; however, power users who want a host of additional features should probably choose GNOME Do or Synapse.

If you’ve ever done a Google search before, you can probably use Synapse. Launching applications and finding files using Synapse is extremely simple. If you’re unhappy with the primary result, use the down arrow key to show a list of alternatives. The side arrow keys allow you to use the filters to narrow your search. Integration with Zeitgeist makes Synapse very effective—it managed to find most of my search queries within seconds. Synapse also has a decent list of plugins, though they are less in number compared to Do. Plugins include the ability to control Banshee and Rhythmbox, search the Web and even perform some basic calculations. These plugins are not always easy to use. For instance, figuring out how to use ‘OpenSearch’ took some time. However, once you learn how to use them, the plugins are simply awesome and a good return on the initial time investment.

All the three programs have the option to automatically start up at login, circumventing the need for any other application launcher to start them.

Which application launcher you wish to use ultimately comes down to personal preference. For users who don’t want too many features and just want to access their favourite applications, GNOME Pie is hard to beat. It is easy to configure, looks good and its circular UI is like a breath of fresh air. For users who would like the ability to search for files and folders along with launching applications, Synapse is a good choice. It has a simple UI and a powerful search, along with a decent number of plugins. For power users who want to do everything from their application launcher, GNOME Do with its huge plugin library is perfect.

If I had to recommend an application launcher to